

GS Concession & Contrast

WHAT THIS STRUCTURE MEANS

Concession and contrast structures allow you to acknowledge the strength of an opposing view while maintaining your own position. At ILR 3, the ability to concede without collapsing is a mark of sophisticated argumentation. When you say 'while it is true that X, the more important point is Y,' you are not weakening your argument — you are showing that you have considered the full picture and still hold your position. This is what distinguishes analysis from assertion.

WHAT TO TRY

- Acknowledge a valid opposing point before returning to your own position
- Use contrast markers to signal the shift: however, nevertheless, while, although, even so
- Distinguish between what is true in limited cases and what holds more broadly
- Concede on a minor point to strengthen your claim on a major one
- Use 'while... the more significant issue is...' to reframe rather than refute

SENTENCE STARTERS

- "While it is true that... the more significant concern is..."
- "This argument has merit in certain contexts; however, when applied broadly..."
- "Even if we accept that point, it does not address..."
- "Critics are correct that... nevertheless, the evidence still suggests..."
- "Although X is a valid concern, it should not overshadow the fact that..."

EXAMPLE IN ACTION

Topic: Should standardized testing be required for university admission?

*"While it is true that standardized tests provide a consistent measure across different school systems, **the more significant issue is whether that consistency reflects actual ability or reflects access to preparation resources.** **Critics are correct that** removing tests entirely creates its own equity problems — subjective criteria **can** introduce different forms of bias. **Nevertheless,** the current system **tends to** reward test preparation rather than academic potential. **Even so,** the answer is **probably not** elimination, but redesign — tests that measure reasoning rather than recall **would likely** produce more meaningful differentiation."*

Bold phrases mark active concession and contrast moves — acknowledging opposing views while holding and advancing the speaker's position.